



VGHF DIGITAL COLLECTION POLICY 2026

SUMMARY

The Video Game History Foundation (VGHF) is a non-profit organization dedicated to preserving, celebrating, and teaching the history of video games. In support of preserving video game history, we support and maintain a free digital library that preserves artifacts related to games history from our physical archive. The focus of the VGHF and our preservation work involves print materials, however we maintain a flexible approach to our collection development, resulting in a wide range of information objects that are included in our collection. Materials available through the digital library are digitally preserved versions of materials that are a part of our physical collection. This document contains information about the policies that guide the digital library's collection development: what we accept, how we manage and preserve collection material, how they are presented and accessed by the public, and how we steward this collection for the longevity of the archive. The primary audiences of the digital library are video game enthusiasts, and those who support the VGHF as well as other game preservation efforts. We also recognize the benefits and responsibilities that supporting this collection has to members of the games industry, as well as other game-focused archive, library and museum efforts around the world. Our organization is driven by patron support and we couldn't do it without you, which is why we publish this policy so that everyone can understand transparently what we do and why we do it. This is especially important for those considering donating to our organization! This is a living document that is subject to change over time, and those changes will be recorded and available on our Github at **[Currently: <https://github.com/SolonCubed/VGHF-collection-development-policy>].**

COLLECTION CRITERIA

As much as we'd love to collect anything and everything related to videogames (short of commercial releases), the VGHF must be particular as to what we can commit our resources towards out of respect to our donors and the longevity of the organization. Our digital library will include any physical materials from the VGHF library that have been digitized as a part of the preservation process and meet the criteria for providing access through the digital library portal. Examples of materials not included in the digital library include: materials that are not in English, materials with contractual or legal restrictions regarding access. Our digital library prioritizes global access with a focus on online accessibility standards so that our library can be accessible to as many people as possible. If you would like to contribute, please donate materials that are novel to our library collection or are higher-quality versions than what we currently have. If you are unsure about quality or interested in donating, please contact us via email with your submission request.

Users of the digital library can expect regular access to all of our materials and the ability to access multiple materials at once. With respect to regional restrictions, any user should expect to be able to access the digital library from any online capable device. You will not need to 'check out' materials, and no web cookies will be tracked by the VGHF while you are using our website. On the physical library side, you can expect us to keep a highly secure facility where materials (including our web servers) are not accessed by anyone without express permission from the director or head librarian. We also offer rights management and timed embargoes for any donors who wish to be included in our collection, but have materials of a more sensitive nature that they wish to preserve.

SELECTION CRITERIA

When the VGHF receives donated materials, they will be professionally inspected on receipt. Artifacts that align with our selection criteria will be added to our collection. Materials may also be deprecated or removed from our library for various reasons. Items not included or removed from

our collection are repurposed for other VGHF programs (e.g., VGHF magazine subscription), or externally connected to an appropriate institution that matches the material's preservation needs. Materials that are not resolved through these methods will be handled on a case by case basis. As a digital library, our goal is to provide access to the highest quality versions of materials through digitally preserving them in as much detail as possible. Since our physical library has limited space we maintain individual copies of the materials in the collection. For donor questions regarding rights management, timed material releases, or other access related concerns regarding materials, please reach out to us directly at any time.

Our current list of materials accepted to the digital library are as follows:

- Mass print materials: magazines, flyers, or art pieces
- Development materials: design documents, concept art, memos, or meeting notes
- Industry materials: convention/expo catalogs, press releases

Video game materials that we can process but currently do not add to our collection:

- Non-development materials: merchandise, promotional goods (swag)
- Game data
- Hardware: controllers, consoles, accessory equipment
- Retail video games
- Web materials: websites, wikis, or digital game reviews
- Video game prototypes

CATALOGING

The VGHF will organize materials within the digital archive in ways that best serve our user population. Our cataloging techniques attempt to evenly expose materials based on how they were produced, and what organizations produced them. As a digital library this is done by continuing to expand our metadata strategies in tandem with managing how our OCR-powered search retrieves collection materials. For an example of each, we organize our collections based on new major additions to the digital archive and we will deprioritize materials that get in the way of productive search results. While cataloging, the VGHF will appraise the condition of materials and determine if at-risk media is most appropriately formatted by us, or if we need to work with other organizations for higher fidelity storage, scan, or emulation. When processing materials we always retain original files as well as their modulations post-processing with the understanding that more powerful preservation techniques could develop in the future. Any changes made to the overall cataloging strategies will be managed by our Head Librarian and explained here.

PRESERVATION

The VGHF's preservation policies stretch across our collections, our equipment, and our organization in order to provide transparency with our libraries' current means of preservation. To best preserve our physical library collection, the VGHF maintains our space with humidity and temperature control systems to keep the materials in top condition. We use high shelving techniques on physical and digital materials to protect from flooding. Our servers are protected from data rot and outside interference. We verify all of our software materials on receipt and determine policies for when we should retain original files of scans as well as any modulations that are made to them on a filetype-by-filetype basis. For the preservation hardware we use, we develop equipment repair and replacements plans and maintain a backup plan for equipment that transforms our materials. The VGHF's organizational strategies are developed with the intent that the organization can be

provisioned at full capacity for, at minimum, the next five years. As our resources improve, these preservation policies can expand to reflect that.

Our list of Organizations we work with for stronger preservation:

[Gaming Alexandria](#) - For materials outside our policy

[Hidden Palace](#) - For rare software materials

[The Cutting Room Floor](#) - For materials cut from game production

[HitSave.org](#) - Modern preservation projects

Internet Archive - [\[Hotlink to the Software Collection\]](#)

[Strong National Museum of Play](#) - The premiere example of a modern videogame museum, great for hardware (Rochester, NY)

[University of Michigan LibGuide](#) - Best resource for scholarly resources and information on other Academic Game Collections - great places for hardware-specific access and support.

[EFGAMP](#) - The European Federation of Video Game Archives and Museums, and Preservation Projects - An aligned conglomeration of Europe's strongest preservation-focused institutions.

Support your wonderful local retro games stores for games hardware needs!

And, of course, [Ebay](#)

COLLECTION SCOPE

The VGHF's digital archive features digitally preserved versions of objects that are maintained by or a part of the VGHF collection. The digital library collection does not represent all materials within the VGHF collection, as materials must complete the preservation process before they are available through the digital library. This includes game-related magazines and historical materials from 1971 to the present day. Current efforts are focused on video game-related print materials, but the scope of the collection may change to reflect the preservation needs of historic game materials.

Current Scope Considerations:

- Printed commercial materials from 1970s-Today
- Donated materials from within 20th century professional game development
- Increased representation of non-US materials
- Representation of oral histories
- Representation of who and where people play have historically played games that challenge 'mainstream' games identity.

USER WARRANT FOR TECHNOLOGY

The VGHF builds this archive for many types of users. The collection should be accessible to all users across the globe as long as the network resolves within the user's country. Our collection services are designed primarily with researchers and historians in mind to give them tools that impact their work within our collection. We will also grow our services with developers in mind, as contemporary work can greatly impact our own work and vice-versa, our services are supportive to active game developers of all shapes and sizes across the current industry. To connect more users to games history, our strategy is to continue building the archive and its preservation strategies so games history can be accessible regardless of devices being used, country, and language.

THIS YEAR'S COLLECTION DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

[This space is reserved for a few bullet points from one Mr. Phil Salvador]

This document will be revised and reauthorized by **[July 2027]**, if today's date is after this posted date, please contact the owner.